

Cover Crops Chart

This table includes different options for your cover crop mix. When possible we recommend including at least one grain and one vegetable in your mix. Choose varieties depending on the time of the season you want to plant your cover crop.

Cover crop	Total days in garden	Minimum temperature for germination	Hardiness zone	When to sow	Inoculum (<i>Rhizobium</i>)	Survive Winter	Note
Legumes (fabaceae) - Fixes atmospheric nitrogen							
Clover	60-70 days	Crimson: 45°F (7°C) Red: 41°F (5°C)	Crimson: 7 Red: 4	Spring to Early Fall	<i>R. trifolii</i>	Yes	Several variants depending on the type of clover chosen. More difficult to destroy, allow a minimum of 4 weeks of occultation. Mix the seeds with sand when sowing.
Common Vetch	60+ days	60°F (16°C)	8	Late Summer to Fall	<i>R. leguminosarum</i>	No	Grows quickly in the fall. Smothers weeds well. Works well mixed with oats in summer.
Field Peas	60-70 days	41°F (5°C)	7	Spring to Late Summer	<i>R. leguminosarum</i>	No	Works well mixed with oats.
Hairy Vetch	60+ days	60°F (16°C)	4	Spring to Early Fall	<i>R. leguminosarum</i>	Yes	Grows more slowly than common vetch. Resistant to cold temperatures. Survives winter well when accompanied by a shelter crop (fall rye).
Melilot	60-70 days	42°F (6°C)	4	Spring to Summer	<i>R. meliloti</i>	Yes	Works well in combination with fall rye.
Cereals (grasses)							
Barley	70 days	38°F (3°C)	7	Spring to Early Fall	-	No	Dies at 18°F (-8°C). Grows quickly and its deep roots promote a good soil structure.
Buckwheat	5-6 weeks	50°F (10°C)	Frost sensitive	Late Spring to Late Summer	-	Yes	Sensitive to cold and frost. Covers the soil quickly: good weed control. Can be used between two crops during summer. Do not mix.
Fall Rye	4-6 weeks	34°F (1°C)	3	Spring to Mid-Fall	-	No	Good choice for late fall seeding. Works well in a mixture with common vetch. More difficult to destroy, allow a minimum of 4 weeks under a tarp.
Oat	70-90 days (minimum 60 days)	38°F (3°C)	8	Spring to Early Fall	-	No	Dies over winter and leaves a thin mulch on the ground in spring.
Spring Wheat	70 days	38°F (3°C)	7	Early Spring	-	No	Can be planted early in the spring.
Winter Wheat	90+ days	39°F (4°C)	3	Spring to Mid-Fall	-	Yes	Good choice for late fall planting.